

College Bound

ISSUES & TRENDS FOR THE COLLEGE ADMISSIONS ADVISOR

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Admissions Watch

Bates Apps Up 24 Percent. Bates C. in Maine, north of Portland, attracted 12,009 applications for its Class of 2030, 24 percent more than last year and the most in the school's 171-year history. Bates' first two rounds of Early Decision resulted in slightly more than half the class committing by January. Overall, the Class of 2030 is expected to welcome about 520 students. Bates offers a combination of a liberal arts curriculum and professional skill development.

Darryl Uy, director of admission, attributed the increase in applications to expanded recruitment efforts from direct contact by Bates' admission counselors traveling in the United States and internationally to increased marketing efforts across multiple platforms and partnerships with organizations committed to access, including QuestBridge.

Bates is now one of 55 selective higher education institutions working with QuestBridge National College Match, the organization that helps prepare high-potential, low-income high school students for college. QuestBridge's motto is "Dream big, a top college is possible." The colleges that select QuestBridge Scholars provide these students with full scholarships.

BC Admits 12 Percent. Boston C. received 40,477 applications for its Class of 2023, 5.6 percent more than last year, according to Grant Gosselin, dean of undergraduate admission and financial aid. Some 95 percent of students admitted to the Class of 2030 ranked in the top 10 percent of their high school class. The average SAT and ACT scores were 1500 and 34, respectively. The average SAT score dropped by 3 points while the average ACT score remained the same for the sixth year in a row.

About 9 percent of accepted students are international, hailing from 89 countries, and the accepted class includes students from all 50 states, Washington, D.C., and two U.S. territories. According to the university, 11 percent

of this year's accepted class is first generation, down from 12 percent of the Class of 2029. BC did not release the number of students who were accepted through the QuestBridge program or who are Pell Grant recipients.

"Since the Supreme Court's Affirmative Action decision, BC has reported two consecutive years of declining AHANA+ student enrollment. AHANA+ students comprise 35 percent of the Class of 2029. The most diverse freshman class remains the Class of 2027, with 38 percent of students identifying as AHANA+," according to *The Heights*.

Georgetown U. Admits 13 Percent. Georgetown U. in Washington D.C. received more than 26,900 applications for its Class of 2030 and admitted just 13 percent of them, one percent more than last year, according to *The Hoya*. GU will enroll about 1,650 new students in the fall. Next year, GW will join 1,100 schools using the Common Application.

Charles Deacon, dean of undergraduate admissions, said the 13 percent admission rate reflects the quality of candidates in its application pool.

Middlebury C. Admits 17 Percent. This past cycle, 11,458 students applied to become members of Middlebury C.'s Class of 2030 and "2030.5," Shannon Palmer, associate director of admissions, told *The Campus*. The distinguished Vermont college acceptance rate was 17 percent, a marked increase from 13.9 percent for the classes of 2029 and 2029.5.

The Campus noted, "as the applicant pool for Middlebury College continues to shrink, a new communications and marketing campaign is helping the college reach areas where it has traditionally seen fewer applications, in the face of an impending demographic cliff affecting the states from which the college has yielded the most students in the past."

Palmer added, "However, we have a very

strong endowment, we have awesome students, we are a selective institution that will always make our class. We have many thousands more students applying to Middlebury than we can ever have space for."

Rice U. Admits 7 Percent. Rice U. in Texas received 38,603 applications for its Class of 2030 and admitted 7.7 percent of them, Yvonne Romero, vice president for enrollment and dean of admissions and financial aid, told the *Rice Thresher*.

President Reggie DesRoche's Momentous strategic plan wants a 5,200 student body by 2028, which requires another 10 percent increase. The graduate population is scheduled to grow to 9,500 total students by 2028.

Tulane U. Admits 15 Percent. Tulane U. in New Orleans fielded more than 32,000 first-year applications for its Class of 2030, and a record number of Early Decision apps, Shawn Abbott, vice president for enrollment management and dean of admission, told the *Tulane Hullabaloo*.

Tulane offers four rounds of admissions: Early Decision, Early Action, Early Decision II and Regular Decision. Only Early Decision and Early Decision II are binding. For its Class of 2029, Tulane extended around 1,100 Regular Decision offers and an equal number of Early Decision spots. So, Early Decision applicants made up just over half of the Class of 2029's enrollment.

Wesleyan U. Admits 15 Percent. Wesleyan U. in Middletown, Connecticut, received 14,820 applications for its Class of 2030, the school's third largest pool, but fewer than last

continued on page 2

INSIDE

- Enrollment Trends
- Outlook (on the Future)
- Books and More

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ENROLLMENT TRENDS

Despite Challenges, California Seeks 70 Percent College Attainment. Yet California has a way to go to reach that goal. According to Jessie Ryan, president of the state's Campaign for College Opportunity, California "will not meet that 70 percent attainment goal if we don't do a better job on delivering better results for our Latinx students, our Black students, our low-income students, and our first-generation students."

However, according to the Public News Service, "The state created the California Education Interagency Council to make sure that leaders from the public school system, community colleges and four-year colleges create seamless pathways to degrees and certificates that match workforce needs. The Cal State schools are now proactively offering admission to students who qualify, without them having to apply." And "Programs called 'associate degree for transfer' have funneled 630,000 students into four-year institutions."

Community C.'s Attract New Students. According to the National Student Clearinghouse Research Center, students aged 18 to 20 represented the largest share of first-time associate degree earners in the 2024-25 academic year—accounting for nearly one-third. For the first time, this age group surpassed those aged 21 to 24, the report found.

"Looming College-Enrollment Death Spiral." An April 12 article in *The Atlantic* by Jeffery Selinger contends that higher education could again become a "luxury good." The U.S. currently supports about 4,000 colleges and universities, and according to the Federal Reserve of Philadelphia, about 60 go out of existence each year. Selinger maintains that given the "demographic cliff" that is affecting enrollment, that number could soon double. Students who typically stay close to home could suffer as a result.

Michigan Faculty Senate Votes to End ED. The U. of Michigan Faculty Senate recently passed a resolution calling on UM's administration to reverse its Early Decision admissions initiative, first tested for the Class of 2030. According to *The Michigan Daily*, the resolution passed with 1,364 yes votes, 424 no votes and 548 abstaining. The Faculty Senate's vote does not compel UM's administration to take such an action but shows the sentiment of the faculty.

According to the paper, chemistry professor Neil Marsh said the decision to add Early Decision admissions benefits the University rather than the students and was made with

little to no consultation from the faculty.

"Faced with increasing application numbers, they identify the students who are keenest to attend," Marsh said. "They can lock in a preset number of students into the entering class. Thus, they make fewer offers and have less uncertainty about the final class size. There is also a significant financial advantage. Early Decision applicants tend to come from wealthier families who can pay full tuition." Marsh said most students relying on financial aid are put at a disadvantage.

UM's Faculty Senate also passed a resolution calling for the administration to create infrastructure allowing faculty to detect when students use AI to complete their work, as well as creating classes for students who want to distance themselves from AI.

Salome Viljoen, assistant professor of law, said, "AI can enhance productivity and the productive capacities of experts, but there's also growing evidence of the risk that AI poses to the cognitive conditions necessary to produce new experts, in particular risks to cultivating perseverance and cooperation."

Oberlin Stability Strategy. *The Oberlin Review* recently noted that applications to the Ohio college's Class of 2029 totaled 10,427, a 7.5 percent increase from the 9,702 received a year earlier. Oberlin's famed Conservatory saw a 41.3 percent increase in applicants, with only 25 percent of the 1,850 first-year applicants admitted.

"This enrollment growth is the administration's way of trying to mitigate transfer rates, retain a certain level of enrollment and graduation rate, and support the financial stability of both the College and the Conservatory in uncertain times," the paper explained.

Louisiana Alerts Students to College Options. In April, the Louisiana Board of Regents, in partnership with the state's public colleges and universities, higher education systems and college-access organizations informed thousands of qualified Louisiana high school students about their next step. Personalized letters linked them to university and community college options based on their academic record and region of the state. The initiative is part of a broader effort to increase college participation and strengthen Louisiana's workforce pipeline. The effort to reach students who have not yet solidified higher education plans is supported by a \$300,000 grant from the Lumina Foundation through its Great Admissions Redesign initiative. Louisiana was selected as one of seven recipients in the program's first national cohort. The initiative seeks to

simplify admissions processes and expand access to higher education for students who might otherwise miss opportunities to enroll, according to *Biz New Orleans*.

"Increasing college-going and supporting student success are critical to achieving our state's attainment goal by 2030," Commissioner of Higher Education Kim Hunter Reed told the paper. "This campaign is part of a larger effort to ensure Louisiana students understand their opportunities and take the necessary steps to support their college and career success." ■

ADMISSIONS WATCH

continued from page 1

year. A total of 2,338 students were admitted across all rounds, for an overall acceptance rate of approximately 15.8 percent, according to *The Argus*. Some 558 were accepted through the two rounds of Early Decision, an increase from 512 last year. The school hopes to enroll 810 new students in the fall.

About 45 percent of admitted students will receive financial aid, 16 percent of admitted students identify as first-generation college students and 12 percent are international students, compared to 10 percent of admitted students for the Class of 2029.

About 67 percent of admitted students submitted their standardized test scores. Median scores remained unchanged at 34 for the ACT and SAT medians of 750 in evidence-based reading and writing and 770 in math.

William & Mary C. Admits 34 Percent. William & Mary C. in Virginia attracted 17,432 applicants for its Class of 2030 and granted admission to 6,001 prospective students for an overall admissions rate of 34 percent, down two percentage points compared to its Class of 2029. W&M received 1,606 Early Decision applications and offered admissions to 760 of them. Students in the admitted class hail from 57 nations, up from last year's 41.

Prospective students of the Class of 2030 recorded a middle-50 percent SAT score range from 1420-1520 and a middle-50 percent ACT score range from 33-35. SAT scores saw a slight increase from 1410-1520, while median ACT scores remained the same.

Associate provost for enrollment and dean of admission Tim Wolfe told *The Flat Hat*, "Based on the academic quality, experiences and talents displayed in the applications of our admitted students, I'm confident this class will make William & Mary proud and be among the best of the best in the nation."

Williams Admits 7.4 Percent. Williams in Massachusetts received 15,534 applicants for its Class of 2030, 1,000 more than last year, and admitted only 7.4 percent, according to the *Williams Record*. ■

Outlook

ON AI

AI Pioneer's Advice on College Majors. Anthropic cofounder Jack Clark told *Business Insider* that it is a great time to be a philosophy major. And for him, literature degrees proved to be a great match for working in AI. He says the best majors involve "synthesis across a whole variety of subjects." In addition to philosophy majors, Anthropic hires other liberal arts majors.

"What turned out to be useful is that I got to learn a lot about history and a lot about the kind of stories that we tell ourselves about the future," Clark said during Semafor's World Economy Summit. "The really important thing is knowing the right questions to ask and having intuitions about what would be interesting, colliders, different insights from many different disciplines," he said.

AI Paradox. MSN recently observed that while AI is transforming the workplace, "More than half of college students say their school either discourages (42 percent) or outright bans (11 percent) the use of AI, according to Gallup. Faculty are aware of the damage: 63 percent believe their schools' 2025 graduates were not very or not at all prepared to use AI in the workplace, per the American Association of Colleges and Universities. But what is the first thing employers are asking for from any qualified candidate? AI literacy."

Double Majors to Surge. "Double-majoring has surged as a hedge against AI disruption, *Fortune* reported in November, and graduates who steered toward so-called AI-proof fields, psychology, education, social work are now finding those degrees carry negative financial returns as AI moves into white-collar work faster than anticipated."

AI Means "Upskilling" Needed. From *The Harbus, the independent newspaper of Harvard's Business School*, April 29: "The Two-Tiered Future of Learning," by Folu Ogunyeye. "A few weeks ago, I sat in on a fireside chat with the CEO of Coursera, hosted by the HBS Education Club and the Harvard Project on Workforce.

He knew his numbers: 15 learners enroll in an AI course on Coursera every minute. If the world were 100 people, 59 of them will need retraining by 2030, according to the World Economic Forum. In response, Coursera has stepped up to the task by partnering with governments to 'upskill' entire populations. Degrees are important, he said, but no longer sufficient to stand out in the age of AI automation. Micro-credentials are therefore the panacea in getting ahead of a monumental epidemic of redundancies and existential crises."

ON THE FUTURE OF ADMISSIONS

NACAC Says It's Time to Update Admissions. At the recent National Association of College Admissions Counseling Center for Innovation in College Admissions event in Washington D.C., several hundred college counselors, admissions leaders, researchers and policymakers gathered to discuss how to modernize the college application process.

"It's decades and decades that we've been conducting admissions in a similar way. And now we find ourselves in the 21st century and we find ourselves with experiments... that are going to upend the profession as we know it unless we think about this proactively," argued Seth Allen, vice president for enrollment management and dean of admissions, at Dickinson C. in Pennsylvania. According to the *Chronicle of Higher Education*, he noted examples of the influence of AI and Direct Admissions making rapid changes.

According to the *Chronicle*, the conference explored three key areas: reinventing structures around the application process, seeking new ways to evaluate a student's college readiness and developing a healthy and diverse admissions workforce.

While there was no agreement on a new direction, new methods were touted by education entrepreneurs including Dialogues developed by Khan Academy founder Sal Khan that brings students together to contribute to anonymous conversations about controversial topics. Dialogues then creates a "portfolio" for each participant that some universities now accept as part of their applications as a way of evaluating a student's civil dialogue skills.

Digital Transcripts. International Big Picture Learning Credential's digital transcript lets students present their competencies, such as critical thinking, collaboration and communication, as well as project-based and experiential learning, instead of grades and the courses they have taken. The approach is already being used in Australia.

Innovations continue to transform how students think about college and how colleges evaluate students they want to bring to campus. Another panel noted that counselors at many U.S. high schools do not have the right advising structures or their advisers would not have the bandwidth to administer the IBPLC digital transcript.

Meanwhile, according to the *Chronicle*, at a discussion on video essays, Allen said that "participants raised concerns about accessibility for students for whom English isn't their first language and questioned whether coaching students on these videos will simply become a new product offered by independent college counselors...." ■

COUNSELOR'S BOOKSELF

The Princeton Review's "Paying for College, Everything You Need to Maximize Financial Aid and Afford College," 2026, shares strategies for completing the 2026-2027 FAFSA and CSS Profile to one's best advantage as well as planning for long- and short-term college costs. ISBN-10 0593518780; \$20.99 (paperback).

The Ultimate College Financial Aid Guide: Understand the Aid Offer & Ask for More Money by Diana Barbu, PhD; ISBN 10: 1736187511;

\$31.89. "Did you know that only 40 percent of the students that enroll in college graduate four years later? Finances can play a significant role in college progression and graduation. That is why understanding financial aid is vital....

"Make sense of the financial aid offer and its elements; Determine your out-of-pocket costs using the information provided through the financial aid letter; Compare colleges on out-of-pocket costs; Ask for more aid to make

college more affordable; Understand what may happen to aid after the freshman year; Determine the maximum amount of debt to take on for your education; Learn how to save thousands on college."

Admissions Chess Game. "The college-admissions chess game is more complicated than ever," by Roshan Fernandez, *Wall Street Journal*, May 1, argues that "Some students have this mentality of being a shopper, being the buyer," said Adam Nguyen, founder of admissions consulting firm Ivy Link. "You're not the buyer; you are at the mercy of these colleges." ■

Where Did the Astronauts Go to College?

Where did the bold astronauts of Artemis II who recently traveled 225,855 miles to the Moon receive their education?

Reid Wiseman (Commander, NASA), *Undergraduate*: Rensselaer Polytechnic Institute, B.S. in Computer & Systems Engineering. *Graduate*: Johns Hopkins U., M.S. in Systems Engineering, U.S. Naval Postgraduate School, Certificate in Space Systems.

Victor J. Glover (Pilot, NASA), *Undergraduate*: California Polytechnic State U., San Luis Obispo, B.S. in General Engineering. *Graduate*: U.S. Air Force Test Pilot School,

M.S. in Flight Test Engineering, Naval Postgraduate School, M.S. in Systems Engineering.

Christina Hammock Koch (Mission Specialist, NASA), *Undergraduate*: North Carolina State U., B.Sc. in Electrical Engineering & Physics. *Graduate*: North Carolina State U., M.Sc. in Electrical Engineering.

Jeremy Hansen (Mission Specialist, Canadian Space Agency), *Undergraduate*: Royal Military C. of Canada, B.Sc. in Space Science. *Graduate*: Royal Military C. of Canada, M.Sc. in Physics (specializing in space science). ■

TESTING TABS

Claremont McKenna C. Reinstates Standardized Tests. Claremont McKenna C., part of the five Claremont Colleges in California, announced it will extend its test-optional policy through the Fall 2027 application cycle but reinstitute its standardized test requirement for students applying for Fall 2028.

According to *The Student Life*, both the test-optional policies at Scripps C. and Pomona C are now permanent. Harvey Mudd C.'s test-optional policy and Pitzer C.'s test-free policy may change for future application cycles.

"In a highly nuanced process, scores are among many factors that help CMC attract, admit and enroll students whose intellect, interests, leadership and professional aspirations align with the College's mission and values," Jennifer Sandoval-Dances, vice

president for admission and financial aid, told the paper.

According to NPR, the number of students who submitted standardized test scores this admissions cycle rose by 10 percent.

Michigan Eliminates Essays. A new law eliminates the essay portion of the Michigan Merit exam for 11 graders. It also states that students will no longer be required to share their scores with university and college admissions offices.

P.S. Crisis in Confidence. "America's colleges and universities are facing a crisis of legitimacy, and Yale University just issued one of the most candid institutional diagnoses yet of how they got here, and what it will take to

CURRICULUM CAPSULES

Princeton U. and The College of New Jersey Team Up. Students at the C. of New Jersey, located five miles north of Trenton, can now take selective, tuition-free classes from Princeton U., the state's premiere Ivy League C., which is about ten miles away. TCNJ enrolls about 8,000 students. The five-year cross-registration agreement allows mostly upper-level students to take courses not offered at their home institution.

"No single institution can offer every specialized course a student might desire," TCNJ's vice provost for academic engagement, Tammy Dieterich, said. "By working together, we're excited to provide this student-centered option and share the unique learning experiences led by our faculty."

DePaul's Institute for Journalism and Racial Justice. This Spring, DePaul U. in Chicago launched an Institute for Journalism and Racial Justice organized around three

core missions: supporting emerging journalists, advancing racial justice in the media and equipping community storytellers through events, workshops and mentoring. It was created through a partnership between DePaul's C. of Communications and the non-profit Public Narrative.

Chris Bury, a DePaul journalism professor and former ABC Nightline correspondent, led a conversation about these issues with former Chicago Mayor Lori Lightfoot.

New Vet School. Arkansas State's new vet school will officially start accepting students for fall.

Law School Apps Soar. According to Law.com, the number of law school applicants in 2025 increased by 18 percent compared to the previous year to reach 76,500, reflecting the single greatest year-over-year increase in applicants since 2004. ■

Financial Spot Checks

Debt Continues to Climb. Around 46 percent of 2026 high school graduates will go on to a four-year college or university, according to a new report by NerdWallet. As college costs continue to rise, incoming freshmen could take on as much as \$43,000, on average, in education debt by graduation, the report says, up from \$40,000. Rising college costs are largely to blame for swelling student debt. And there are fewer repayment options and stricter rules for loan forgiveness compared to previous years. Currently, around 42.8 million Americans hold \$1.696 trillion in federal student loans, and more than one million high school graduates will take out new education debt in the months ahead, higher education expert Mark Kantrowitz told CNBC.

Georgia Schools Boost Tuition. The U. System of Georgia approved a tuition increase for the upcoming academic year of 1 percent for in-state students and 3 percent for out-of-state and international students. ■

climb out," read a headline on *Yahoo News*.

The Yale report offered "a blunt assessment of the sector's failures on cost, admissions, free speech and governance."

Yahoo cited Gallup and Pew polling that noted that "Just a decade ago, 57 percent of Americans said they had a great deal or quite a lot of confidence in higher education. By 2024, that figure had fallen to a historic low of 36 percent."

Though trust ticked upward slightly in 2025, 70 percent of Americans still say higher education is 'heading in the wrong direction.' And no corner of academia faces more skepticism than the Ivy League, the very institutions that have long positioned themselves as the gold standard."

The Yale report observed that, "In recent years, universities have been expected to be all things to all people: selective but inclusive, affordable but luxurious, meritocratic but equitable.... Rather than build public support, this diffusion of purpose has contributed to distrust."

Among its 20 recommendations, the report urged establishing clearer academic standards in admissions, reducing or eliminating legacy preferences, reining in grade inflation and strengthening free-expression norms.

The full report and related material can be found at: <https://president.yale.edu/posts/2026-04-15-report-of-the-committee-on-trust-in-higher-education>. ■

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